A. NILESH FERNANDO

(N) 4.24, Bush House, Department of Economics, King's College London
(+44) 020 7848 5535 nilesh.fernando@kcl.ac.uk http://nileshfernando.com

EDUCATION

Harvard University, Cambridge, MA 2010-2015
Ph.D. Public Policy (Fields: Labor and Development Economics)
Thesis: *"Land, Labor, and Technology: Essays in Development Economics"*

University of Oxford, Oxford, UK 2009-2010
Graduate-level coursework in Mathematics and Economics

Hampshire College, Amherst, MA 2003-2007
B.A. Mathematics and Economics, Minor: Public Policy

ACADEMIC POSITIONS

King's College London, London, UK 2025 - *
Associate Professor, Department of Economics, King's Business School

University of Notre Dame, Notre Dame, IN 2016-2025
Assistant Professor, Department of Economics
Concurrent Assistant Professor, Keough School of Global Affairs

Harvard University, Cambridge, MA 2015-2016
Postdoctoral Fellow, Department of Economics

Sabbaticals/Visits

University of Chicago, Chicago, IL 2025-2026
Visiting Scholar, Development Innovation Lab (DIL)

Northwestern University, Evanston, IL 2019-2020
Visiting Scholar, Department of Economics

EXTERNAL AFFILIATIONS

Bureau for Research and Economic Analysis of Development (BREAD) 2024-Present
Affiliate

Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab (J-PAL), Cambridge, MA 2022-Present
Faculty Affiliate

Verité Research, Colombo, Sri Lanka 2017-Present
Research Affiliate

Precision Development (PxD), Cambridge, MA 2015-Present
Research Affiliate

OTHER EMPLOYMENT

Research Assistant, Evidence for Policy Design, Harvard Kennedy School 2014

Research Associate, Centre for Micro Finance/MIT-Poverty Action Lab, India 2008-2009

Research Associate, Harvard Business School, Cambridge, MA 2007-2008

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

9. "The Grass is *Not* Always Greener: The Effects of Local Labor Market Information on Search and Employment," with Niharika Singh, ***Journal of Development Economics***, Vol. 185, 2027.

8. "Regulation by Reputation? Intermediaries, Labor Abuses, and International Migration," with Niharika Singh, ***Review of Economics and Statistics***, Vol. 108, Issue 5, 2026, pp. 1222–1238.

7. "Peer Pressure and Discrimination: Evidence from International Cricket," with Siddharth Eapen George, ***Journal of Law, Economics, and Organization***, Vol. 40, Issue 3, Nov., 2024.

6. "Hiring Frictions and the Promise of Online Job Portals: Evidence from India," with Niharika Singh, and Gabriel Tourek, ***American Economic Review-Insights***, Vol. 5, Issue 4, Dec., 2023.

5. "Shackled to the Soil? Inherited Land, Birth Order, and Labor Mobility," ***The Journal of Human Resources***, Vol. 57, Issue 2, Spring, 2022.

4. "Understanding Adverse Outcomes in Gulf Migration: Evidence from Administrative Data from Sri Lanka," with Alison Lodermeier, ***International Migration Review***, Vol. 56, Issue 1, 2022.

3. "Seeking Treatment: The Impact of Mobile Extension on Information Exchange among Farmers," ***Journal of Development Economics***, Vol. 153, Nov., 2021.

2. "Mobile'izing Agricultural Advice: Technology Adoption, Diffusion, and Sustainability," with Shawn Cole, ***Economic Journal***, Vol. 131, Issue 633, Jan., 2021.

1. "Field Comparisons of Incentive-Compatible Preference Elicitation Techniques," with Shawn Cole, Daniel Stein, and Jeremy Tobacman, ***Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization***, Vol. 172, Apr., 2020.

WORKING PAPERS

10. "Present Mothers, Absent Children? The Effects of Migration Restrictions in Sri Lanka," with Alison Lodermeier and Paul Shaloka.

11. "Fraternity or Fracture? National Identity, Religious Minorities, and Communal Violence in India," with Layton Hall.

12. "Agricultural Extension, Technology Adoption, and Information Spillovers: Evidence from a Cluster Randomized Experiment," with Shawn Cole, Raissa Fabregas, and Hee Kwon Seo.

NON-REFEREED PUBLICATIONS/INVITED POLICY WRITING

"To Protect the Welfare of Sri Lankan Migrant Workers, Hold Recruitment Agencies Accountable," *Daily Mirror*, 2024.

"How can online job portals help firms find workers? Evidence from India," with Niharika Singh and Gabriel Tourek, *VoxDev*, 2023.

"Mobile Phone-Based Extension, Peer Interactions, and Farmer Information Exchange: Evidence from Gujarat," with Renee Yaseen, *VoxDev*, 2022.

"Digital Agricultural Extension: Stimulating or Supplanting Farmers Interactions?" with Renee Yaseen, *Ideas for India*, 2022.

"Assessing the Importance of Financial Literacy," with Shawn Cole, *Asian Development Bank, Finance for the Poor Quarterly*, Volume 9, Number 3, September 2008.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

UG - Undergraduate; G - Ph.D.

King's College London 2026-*

5QQMN938 - Intermediate Econometrics (Tutorial Leader, UG)

University of Notre Dame 2016-2025

ECON 43810 - Explaining an Unequal World: Empirical Methods in Development (UG) - *9 semesters*

ECON 70562 - Advanced Topics in Economic Development (G) - *2 semesters*

ECON 30331 - Econometrics (UG) - *2 semesters*

ECON 70572 - Microeconomic Development II: Market Failures (G) - *1 semester*

ECON 33811 - Introduction to Development Economics (UG) -*1 semester*

Harvard University 2010-2015

Exec Ed - Re-thinking Financial Inclusion: Smart Design for Policy and Practice* - *1 week*

Economics 1393 - Poverty and Development, Department of Economics (UG) - *1 semester*

*- executive education course

ADVISING AND MENTORSHIP

Undergraduate Theses:	***Honors***
Grace Hatfield (ND '24)	
James Mancini (ND '23)	*BonAnno* Thesis Prize
Elena Esteve (ND '21)	
Alison Lodermeier (ND '17)	*BonAnno* Honorable mention
Adam Ramos (ND '17)	
Daniel Martin (ND '16)	*BonAnno* Thesis Prize

Christian Kamm (ND '16)

Doctoral Theses:	***Placement***
Paul Shaloka (ND '23)	*Equal Employment Opportunity Commission*
Linh Nguyen (ND '20)	*Bates College*

Research Assistants/Pre-Doctoral Fellows:	***Placement***
Renee Yaseen (ND '22)	*Washington Post Op-Ed Columnist*
Mika Inoue (ND '20)	*University of Michigan Economics Ph.D.*
Mehak Siddiquei (ND MGA '18)	*Acacia Center for Justice*
Alison Lodermeier (ND '17)	*Brown University Economics Ph.D.*
Sharvari Ravishankar (2020-22)	*JPAL Policy Analyst*
Samiskshya Siwakoti (2019-20)	*Columbia University M.A.*
Pankhuri Jha (2018-19)	*Harvard Kennedy School MPAID*
Thashiya Nauki (2018-19)	*Verité Research*

HONORS, FELLOWSHIPS, AND GRANTS

Research Awards

Total Research Funding Raised: $941,120

Building Inclusive Growth (BIG) Lab, Research Grant	2022
Kellogg Institute, Working Group Grant, University of Notre Dame (x3)	2021-23
Kellogg Institute, Research Grant, University of Notre Dame (x8)	2018-22
Provost's Resilience & Recovery Fund, University of Notre Dame	2021
SGB Evidence Fund, International Growth Centre	2020
ATAI Research Grant, MIT, co-PI with S. George, W. Brooks, & K. Donovan	2019[1]
Ford Family Grant, University of Notre Dame (x2)	2018, 2019
RSP Regular Faculty Grant, Notre Dame Research	2018
Research Grant, World Bank Research Group	2015, 2018
ISLA, Small Grants, University of Notre Dame (x3)	2017, 2018, 2019
ISLA, Large Grant, University of Notre Dame	2018
Luksburg Foundation Grant, University of Notre Dame	2017
JPAL Urban Services Initiative, MIT, co-PI with N. Singh, & G. Tourek	2016
Research Grant, Weiss Family Fund for Development, co-PI with N. Singh	2015
Research Grant, Sustainability Science Program, Harvard Kennedy School	2014
USAID-Development Innovation Ventures, co-PI with S. Cole	2013
Norberg-Bohm Doctoral Fellowship, Harvard Kennedy School	2012-2013
Agriculture Technology Adoption Initiative (ATAI), MIT, co-PI with S. Cole	2012

Teaching Awards[2]

[1] Grant awarded but turned down.

[2] Awards prior to 2023-24 recognize the highest rated course, thereafter a threshold system was introduced recognizing multiple courses.

Department of Economics Teaching Award, University of Notre Dame 2024-25
Undergraduate Elective (Empirical Methods in Development)

Department of Economics Teaching Award, University of Notre Dame 2023-24
Undergraduate Elective (Empirical Methods in Development)

Department of Economics Teaching Award, University of Notre Dame 2022-23
Best Core-Course (Econometrics)

Department of Economics Teaching Award, University of Notre Dame 2021-22
Best Undergraduate Elective (Empirical Methods in Development)

Department of Economics Teaching Award, University of Notre Dame 2020-21
Best Undergraduate Elective (Empirical Methods in Development)

Department of Economics Teaching Award, University of Notre Dame 2018-19
Best Undergraduate Elective (Empirical Methods in Development)

Department of Economics Teaching Award, University of Notre Dame 2017-18
Best Undergraduate Elective (Empirical Methods in Development)

Other Awards

Sustainability Science Doctoral Fellowship, Harvard Kennedy School 2013-2014

Harvard Kennedy School Graduate Fellowship 2010-2012

Full Tuition Grant, Hampshire College 2003-2007

INVITED SEMINARS AND CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

2024-2025: Harvard Kennedy School Growth Lab Seminar, Kellogg Institute Panel on COVID & Poverty, Western Michigan University Economics Seminar, University of Texas-Austin Economics Seminar, University of Warwick Economics Seminar, Simon Fraser University Economics Seminar, King's College London Economics Seminar, Amherst College Economics Seminar

2015-2024: Northwestern University Economics Seminar, World Bank/LISER Conference on Migration, University of California-San Diego Economics Seminar, Conference on Growth and Economic Development: Indian Statistical Institute, Boston University Economics Seminar, Barcelona Graduate School of Economics Summer Forum/Migration Workshop, CEPR-Misum-SITE Development Economics Conference, Korean Development Institute-World Bank Conference, University of Michigan-Ann Arbor Economics Seminar, IUPUI Economics Seminar, Amherst College Economics Seminar, Development Day (University of Chicago), University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign Economics Seminar, Pacific Conference for Development Economics (USC), Northwestern University Development Economics Workshop, Yale Research Initiative on Innovation and Scale (Y-RISE), Human Capital, History, Demography, and Development (H2D2) Conference (Michigan), Northeastern Universities Development Consortium (Tufts), APPAM, Johns Hopkins-SAIS Invited Lecture, Pacific Conference for Development Economics (UCSD), Northeastern Universities Development Consortium (MIT), National Bureau of Economic Research(NBER)-Digitization Conference (Stanford), Midwest International Economic Development Conference (Wisconsin), Ministry of Planning, Government of Sri Lanka, Verité Research (Sri Lanka), World Bank DECRG, Georgetown-Qatar, University of Notre Dame,

ACADEMIC SERVICE

Seminars & Conferences:

Primary Organizer of weekly ND Development Economics Lunch/Workshop (2016-24).

Co-organized the ND-ITAM Poverty and Development Economics Research Conference, Mexico City, Mexico (2023), in partnership with ND International.

Primary Organizer of the New Frontiers in Development Lecture Series (2019, 2023) in partnership with the Kellogg Institute.

Primary Organizer of the ND-PUC Conference in Development Economics, Santiago, Chile (2018) in partnership with ND International.

Co-organized ND Mini-Conferences in Development Economics (2017, 2018).

Referee Service: *Agricultural Economics*, *American Journal of Agricultural Economics*, *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, *American Economic Review*, *American Economic Review-Insights*, *Economic Journal*, *Economic Development and Cultural Change*, *Environment and Development Economics*, *Journal of African Economies*, *Journal of Comparative Economics*, *Journal of Development Economics*, *Journal of Development Effectiveness*, *Journal of the European Economic Association*, *Journal of Environmental Economics and Management*, *Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization*, *Journal of Human Resources*, *Journal of Politics*, *Journal of Political Economy*, *Quantitative Economics*, *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, *Review of Economics and Statistics*, *PLOS ONE*, *World Bank Economic Review*, *World Development*

Grant Review: Weiss Fund, USAID-DIV (Agriculture/Development), 3ie, DAISI, SGB Evidence Fund, Kellogg Institute Grants Committee

OTHER

Languages: English, Sinhalese, Spanish (Basic), Hindi (Basic)

Last updated: August 19, 2026